IELTS ACADEMIC · STUDENT WORKSHEET

IELTS Academic Set 21

All sections

Name: _____ Date: _____

HOW TO USE THIS WORKSHEET

Work through each IELTS part in order. Reading passages stay with their questions; charts and diagrams appear next to their tasks. Open the live practice page for Listening audio and Speaking recordings.

Staff solutions and scripts are supplied separately.

Listening

Use the separately supplied audio. Write one response for each question.

IELTS-style Listening Set 21 - Question Paper

Unofficial practice material. Time allowed: approximately 30 minutes. There are four parts and 40 questions. You will hear each recording once only.

Part 1 - Questions 1-10

Questions 1-6

Complete the form below.

Write **NO MORE THAN ONE WORD AND/OR A NUMBER** for each answer.

Temporary storage booking

Booking detail	Information
Customer name	Noah **1** _____
Storage starting date	**2** _____ October
Recommended unit size	**3** _____ square feet
Latest access required	**4** _____ p.m.
Fragile items	two framed **5** _____
Declared value of goods	£**6** _____

Questions 7-10

Complete the table below.

Write **NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER** for each answer.

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Optional service	Details
Collection van	Price: £**7** _____
Protective pack	Includes blankets and **8** _____
Security lock	A **9** _____ lock is supplied
Refundable deposit	Normally returned within **10** _____ working days

Part 2 - Questions 11-20

Questions 11-15

Which action does the fire-safety officer recommend in each situation?

Choose **FIVE** answers from the box and write the correct letter, **A-G**, next to Questions 11-15.

Actions

A. request a free inspection

B. move a heater away from furniture

C. fit a heat alarm

D. use a fire blanket

E. close internal doors

F. lock internal doors

G. replace an extension lead

11. Cooking frequently activates the smoke alarm. _____

12. A resident is uncertain whether the whole home is adequately protected. _____

13. Several high-powered appliances share one electrical connection. _____

14. A resident wants greater protection while the household is asleep. _____

15. A portable heater is positioned beside an armchair. _____

Questions 16-20

Answer the questions below.

Write **NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER** for each answer.

16. Which street will receive free inspection visits on Tuesday?

_____

17. What document should residents ask to see before opening the door?

_____

18. Where must the second smoke alarm be fitted in a two-storey home?

_____

19. How often should household alarms be tested?

_____

20. What telephone number should residents use to change an appointment?

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_____

Part 3 - Questions 21-30

Questions 21-25

Choose the correct letter, **A, B or C**.

21. What problem does Aisha identify in the students' original sample?

A. It represents only one employment sector.

B. It includes too many participants.

C. It concentrates on workers of a similar age.

22. Who will take part in the pilot interviews?

A. council employees who currently work at night

B. experienced interviewers from the local archive

C. archive volunteers who previously worked night shifts

23. Which recording format do the speakers choose?

A. audio only

B. video only

C. both audio and video

24. How will the main interview be organised?

A. Events will be discussed in chronological order.

B. Participants will choose from a set of topic cards.

C. Every participant will receive the same fixed questions.

25. What will be the main measure of the archive's success?

A. the total number of interviews collected

B. the average length of each interview

C. the range of occupations represented

Questions 26-30

What solution do the speakers choose for each design problem?

Choose **FIVE** answers from the box and write the correct letter, **A-G**, next to Questions 26-30.

Solutions

A. make a pre-interview information call

B. use pseudonyms

C. lend out a simple recorder

D. divide the interview into two shorter sessions

E. create a keyword index

F. ask participants to approve the transcript

G. retain all background sound

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26. Some participants do not want their identities made public. _____

27. A long interview may be tiring after a night shift. _____

28. Useful memories may occur when an interviewer is unavailable. _____

29. The recordings may be difficult for researchers to search. _____

30. Written transcripts may contain errors. _____

Part 4 - Questions 31-40

Questions 31-36

Complete the notes below.

Write **ONE WORD ONLY** for each answer.

Preserving and identifying ancient seeds

Waterlogged deposits

- The lack of oxygen limits the activity of **31** _____.
- Plant remains can survive inside waterlogged wooden structures.

Recovery and identification

- Sediment is transported in sealed **32** _____.
- The upper sieve has the widest **33** _____.
- Final identification is carried out using a **34** _____.
- Ancient material is compared with modern specimens in a reference **35** _____.
- Seeds introduced by modern roots are treated as **36** _____.

Questions 37-40

Complete the flow chart below.

Write **NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS** for each answer.

Interpreting a grain-processing site

Residues from separate activity areas are compared

↓

Broken stalks in the outer yard indicate **37** _____

↓

Small weed seeds in the covered room indicate **38** _____

↓

Grain beside the hearth had probably been **39** _____

↓

The absence of **40** _____ suggests that grain was not stored for long

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Reading

Read the three passages and answer Questions 1-40. Enter or select each answer on screen. This practice is untimed; the IELTS Academic Reading test allows 60 minutes.

Original unofficial practice material aligned to the public IELTS Academic Reading format. It is not an official IELTS test.

Building a Dry-Stone Wall That Holds Together

A A dry-stone wall may look informal, yet its construction follows a disciplined sequence rather than the chance piling of rock. Its recognised profile and finish respond to the size, shape and composition of local stone, so a form familiar in one district need not be copied elsewhere. Before building starts, usable material is sorted into broad working groups. Building stones will form the two visible faces, through stones are reserved to connect those faces, and coping stones are kept for the top.

B The first constructed layer is the footing, which gives remaining courses a firm base. Work begins by clearing weak material until firm ground or firm stones are reached and, where the guidance calls for it, preparing a shallow trench. The largest suitable stones are normally chosen for this beginning and are arranged so that they sit securely. Irregular spaces beneath them are packed with stone rather than left to make the footing rock. Fine loose fill is not a substitute for careful placement, and the bounded guidance also excludes concrete and mortar from this dry construction.

C From the footing upward, the two faces do not rise vertically at a constant width. They follow a batter: an even inward taper that makes the wall wider at its base and narrower at its top. Simple guide lines or frames can help a builder judge this changing profile while the courses rise. The important quality is consistency along the work, not a sudden change at one convenient point. A local profile may be slight, but it should remain even on both faces. Visible bulges or depressions are warnings that the intended line has been lost and that the wall may be weakened.

D The wall is built as two faces with a centre between them, but the faces must not behave as unrelated skins. Face stones are graded as the work rises, and their longer dimension is directed inward rather than laid along the visible surface. Vertical joints are covered by stones in the course above, avoiding continuous gaps through successive layers. Neighbouring pieces are brought into useful contact and the face is checked for openings that reveal daylight. At selected stages, through stones extend across the wall and tie its two sides together. The result depends on overlap, inward length and face connections working together throughout the build.

E As each face course is formed, the middle is filled with hearting, the smaller irregular stone used between the faces. Hearting is placed and packed during the same course, rather than tipped into a deep hollow after the faces have climbed far ahead. Pieces are selected to occupy awkward spaces, while very small loose material is not treated as a complete solution. The centre should become compact without being mistaken for a sealed block. Packing supports the orderly relationship between the two faces and prepares an even level for the next course. A qualitative check is direct: the finished work and its hearting should feel solid and should not move when tested by impact.

F The final full course does not by itself complete the wall. Coping stones are fitted along the top to make an even upper line and are packed tightly enough to remain steady. Their weight is directed onto the top face stones rather than onto an uncertain empty space. At a wall head or exposed end, runners or tying pieces and carefully placed end coping provide a stable finish. The builder checks the height visually along the work and adjusts individual stones before declaring the line complete. The close of the sequence therefore repeats the same habits seen below: selection, contact, packing and checking.

G Repair begins with a decision about where reliable construction resumes, not with covering the most obvious surface gap. Damaged work is dismantled back to sound construction so that the new section can join material that is still firm. Recovered stones are sorted again, preserving suitable building, through and coping pieces for their proper positions. Rebuilding then follows the original order: establish the base, restore an even batter, connect the faces, pack the hearting and finish the top. An even top line and consistent face profile allow the rebuilt section to meet the retained wall without an abrupt change. What appears to be removal is therefore constructive preparation: sound work supplies the starting point for sound rebuilding.

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Questions 1-7

Choose the correct heading for each paragraph from the list below. Select the correct Roman numeral, i-ix, for Questions 1-7. Use each heading only once.

i	Preparing a secure beginning below the wall
ii	Taking failed work back before rebuilding begins
iii	Connecting both faces through deliberate stone placement
iv	How local materials guide the building plan
v	Completing the wall top and exposed ends
vi	Choosing machinery to accelerate movement of stone
vii	Maintaining an even taper from base to top
viii	Recording the ownership of walls across generations
ix	Filling the centre as each course rises

1. Paragraph A

2. Paragraph B

3. Paragraph C

4. Paragraph D

5. Paragraph E

6. Paragraph F

7. Paragraph G

Questions 8-13

Complete each sentence with NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS from the passage. Type your answer in the gap.

8. Before construction, usable material is sorted into broad _____.

9. The largest suitable stones may have irregular spaces beneath them packed with _____.

10. The passage's technical construction name for the profile checked with guide lines or frames is _____.

11. At selected stages, pieces reserved under the two-word name _____ are brought into use.

12. Very small loose material is not treated as a complete _____.

13. The repeated building habits include selection, contact, packing and _____.

What Environmental Tracers Can Say About Groundwater Recharge

A When hydrogeologists assign a date using a dissolved marker, the result needs careful wording. A tracer age refers to when a particular chemical substance entered the water; it is not automatically the age of the water itself. That distinction matters because each tracer carries a record shaped by its own history and properties. The interpretation is conditional rather than a simple reading from a chemical dial. These applications do not turn a measured concentration into a direct clock for one indivisible body of water. Instead, the date is an inference whose meaning depends on the chosen tracer and the assumptions used to interpret it.

B The broad label environmental tracer includes CFCs, tritium and other chemical or isotopic substances measured in groundwater. Their historical records differ, which is one reason they are considered together rather than treated as

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interchangeable. The atmospheric tritium signal discussed in the evidence is linked to nuclear detonations during the 1950s and early 1960s. CFCs, by contrast, are associated with refrigeration and other uses extending from the 1950s through the 1980s. Those source histories supply chronological reference points, but they do not by themselves explain every process between atmosphere and sample. Nor does the shared label mean that the substances have identical origins or respond identically in an analysis.

C Each candidate tracer offers a bounded piece of chronological evidence rather than a complete timetable. For CFCs, roughly fifty years of recorded atmospheric amounts provide one basis for groundwater dating. Tritium has a half-life of 12.4 years and is useful in work on young groundwater, although tritium data alone can be difficult to evaluate for age. Another substance, sulfur hexafluoride or SF6, entered industrial production in 1953 in connection with gas-filled high-voltage electrical switches. The dates and numerical property in these records are informative, yet none makes a single tracer universally sufficient. The responsible question is not which marker always wins, but what temporal constraint each record can defensibly provide.

D Measured values may also require treatment before they are used to calibrate an age distribution. In one cited investigation, tracer concentrations other than tritium received analytical corrections before calibration. Relevant uncertainty factors listed in the evidence include the water-table temperature during recharge and the entrapment of excess air at recharge. These factors are named here because they affect interpretation, not to supply a general account of their chemistry. The passage likewise does not assume that one factor is always larger than the other. A correction is part of the route from an observed concentration to an inference; it is not evidence that the uncorrected number directly states an age.

E A further complication arises when a well contains a mixture of younger and older water. Such mixing can affect the CFC concentration measured in the well. Consequently, assigning one literal recharge date to the whole sample can conceal the presence of different components. An apparent tracer age in this setting is not a birth certificate for a single parcel. Researchers instead use the concentration as evidence within a model that can represent an age distribution. The model may still be useful, but its output remains a model-mediated estimate. This is why concentration, correction, mixing and age cannot be treated as four names for the same observation.

F One approach is to fit a lumped-parameter model to several environmental-tracer observations. In this usage, the model is a compact way of estimating a distribution of recharge times rather than identifying the exact history of every molecule. The fitting process draws on corrected analytical values and on assumptions about how ages are distributed. Its sensitivity can be tested by changing parameters instead of accepting the first output as inevitable. For example, changing a fitted dispersion parameter can produce a younger mean age. That shift does not show that the water itself has suddenly become younger; it shows that the inferred mean depends on model form and parameter choice. Agreement across tracers is therefore evidence to examine, not permission to erase the assumptions behind it.

G The practical value of age information lies in disciplined use rather than claims of perfect dating. An estimated age distribution can contribute to recharge-rate calculations and can improve the structure or calibration of a hydrologic model. Those uses connect observations in wells with questions about movement through a water-supply catchment. They are strongest when analysts state which tracer record, correction and mixing assumptions support the estimate. A result should therefore be read as conditional evidence, open to revision if another tracer or model reveals a different distribution. The central lesson is methodological: environmental tracers constrain recharge history, but only through a chain of interpretation. Protecting every link in that chain makes the conclusion narrower, and also more useful.

Questions 14-20

Do the following statements agree with the information in Reading Passage 2? Select TRUE if the statement agrees with the information, FALSE if it contradicts the information, or NOT GIVEN if the passage gives no information about this.

14. A tracer age identifies when a substance entered water rather than necessarily dating the water itself.

15. The meaning of a tracer age is independent of which tracer is selected.

16. The passage states that conditional wording for tracer ages was first adopted in the 1980s.

17. Changing a fitted dispersion parameter can produce a younger estimated mean age.

18. The passage identifies the software used to fit the lumped-parameter model.

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19. Agreement across several tracers allows analysts to discard the assumptions behind the model.

20. An inferred mean age is independent of both model form and parameter choice.

Questions 21-26

Which paragraph contains the following information? Select the correct letter, A-G, for each question. You may use any letter more than once.

1	A
2	B
3	C
4	D
5	E
6	F
7	G

21. an explanation for combining tracers while preserving differences between their records

22. a compact approach that represents recharge times collectively rather than tracing every molecule

23. the role of data adjustment between a measured value and a dating conclusion

24. uses of age-distribution evidence in recharge calculations and hydrologic models

25. the length of the atmospheric CFC record available for dating

26. a warning that four parts of the analysis are not interchangeable descriptions of one observation

A Universal Kilogram, Unevenly Realised

A For much of its modern history, the kilogram was defined through the mass of the International Prototype of the Kilogram. That arrangement made a single artefact conceptually central to the unit used elsewhere. Replacing the artefact basis promised a definition not tied to one stored object. A definition states what the unit is; laboratories still need a defensible way to establish mass values from it. The argument of this passage is that universality at the definitional level is real, while universality in practical access must be achieved through methods, comparison and dissemination.

B The kilogram is now defined using a fixed value of the Planck constant, and the former prototype no longer realises mass. The selected numerical value of that constant preserved continuity with the previous definition of the unit. To realise a unit is to establish a value, together with its associated uncertainty, for a quantity of the same kind as that unit. The uncertainty belongs inside the statement of a realisation, not outside it as an embarrassing afterthought. Thus the new definition removes dependence on one defining artefact without removing the need for measurement work or physical mass standards used in calibration.

C One primary route employs a Kibble balance. At the level needed here, its defining relation is a comparison in which electrical power is equated with mechanical power. That concise description is important because it explains the kind of bridge the instrument creates without turning the passage into an operating manual. The route connects a mass realisation to experimentally established quantities, but the connection must still be made by an actual instrument. It would therefore be a mistake to argue that fixing a constant has made realisation equipment unnecessary.

D The x-ray crystal density method, or XRCD, expresses the mass of a pure substance in terms of its number of elementary entities. In this approach an unknown mass can be compared with the mass of a specified-isotope atom by counting atoms in a crystal. Single crystals of silicon are often used because large crystals with high chemical purity and no dislocations can be obtained. Together, the Kibble and XRCD routes show that the definition does not depend on only one practical technique. Two independent methods can reach relative uncertainties within a few parts in one hundred million, but

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that capability does not guarantee that every result will agree automatically. Method diversity strengthens the system only when the outcomes can also be compared.

E International comparison is therefore part of the achievement, not a ceremonial step added after it. The BIPM, coordinating with the Consultative Committee for Mass and Related Quantities, organises a key comparison for laboratories operating primary realisation methods. When individual results remain dispersed, national metrology institutes with a kilogram realisation use a consensus value to preserve international equivalence. The value is internationally agreed, but agreement does not replace measurement. This arrangement qualifies the simple claim that independent access to a constant must immediately produce identical masses everywhere. A universal definition supports comparison; comparison and consensus make practical equivalence more robust.

F Mass dissemination passes the kilogram onward through calibrations of customer weights and weight sets. The definition itself does not imply or favour any particular method of realisation, so this calibration-based route remains necessary rather than obsolete. A newer tabletop Kibble route is described as enabling gram-level realisation on site, linked to voltage and resistance standards and ultimately to the Planck constant. This is a specific traceability route, not a claim that every institution already has equal capability. The chain from definition to primary method, comparison, agreed value and calibration shows why changing the first link cannot replace all the later ones. Later steps preserve a usable relation between primary work and ordinary weights.

G A one-kilogram Kibble balance at a national metrology institute can occupy a room, cost extremely large sums and require expert operators. Tabletop work points toward on-site realisation at the gram level and may bring the practical route closer to more laboratories. But scaling farther from the one-kilogram benchmark adds uncertainties, so smaller equipment is not simply a complete replacement with the size reduced. The contrast reveals a premise that optimistic accounts often omit: a method can be permitted by a universal definition and still demand scarce equipment or knowledge. Progress in instrument design may narrow that gap, but the definition alone does not tell us when, where or for whom it will disappear.

H The strongest counterclaim is that once any competent laboratory may realise the kilogram from a constant, decentralisation has already been accomplished. That claim correctly recognises the freedom created by a method-neutral definition, but it compresses permission, capability and equivalence into one idea. A laboratory needs a workable method; its result must sit within comparison and consensus arrangements; and users receive the unit through calibration. Room-scale instruments and emerging tabletop routes demonstrate that practical capability can vary even under the same definition. The removal of a unique defining artefact has solved one specific dependency, while reliable universality in use still ultimately depends on realisation, comparison and dissemination. Equal definition is therefore a foundation for access, not evidence that equal access has already arrived.

Questions 27-33

Do the following statements agree with the views or claims of the writer in Reading Passage 3? Select YES if the statement agrees with the writer's view or claim, NO if it contradicts the writer's view or claim, or NOT GIVEN if the writer's view or claim is not stated.

27. Under the former kilogram arrangement, no single artefact was central to the definition used elsewhere.

28. Under the new definition, reporting associated uncertainty remains part of realising the kilogram.

29. The writer considers maintaining a Kibble balance more difficult than fixing a constant.

30. The writer uses the availability of pure, dislocation-free silicon crystals to explain why silicon is often chosen for XRCD.

31. The writer believes the BIPM should organise key comparisons more frequently.

32. The writer treats a smaller Kibble balance as a complete replacement for the one-kilogram system.

33. The writer acknowledges that a method-neutral definition creates genuine freedom for competent laboratories.

Questions 34-40

Choose the correct answer, A, B, C or D, for each question.

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34. Which distinction frames the main argument in paragraph A?

A International definitions matter more than the methods used by national laboratories.

B A universal definition does not by itself create universal practical access.

C Mass values can be established without methods, comparisons or dissemination.

D A stored artefact and a fixed constant provide equally accessible definitions.

35. What did the selected numerical value of the Planck constant achieve?

A It removed uncertainty from every later mass measurement.

B It made calibration standards unnecessary in laboratories.

C It deliberately changed the size of the kilogram as a measurement unit.

D It preserved continuity with the previous definition of the unit.

36. Why does the writer give a concise account of the Kibble balance's defining relation?

A To explain the bridge the instrument creates without giving an operating manual.

B To compare the running costs of two primary methods.

C To show that the instrument works without established quantities.

D To provide detailed instructions for operating the balance.

37. What is the main value of presenting both primary routes in paragraph D?

A They prove that all realisation results are automatically identical.

B They allow one method to avoid reporting measurement uncertainty.

C They provide independent techniques whose outcomes can be compared.

D They make silicon the required material for every kilogram method.

38. What role does a consensus value play according to paragraph E?

A It ends the need for primary laboratories to make measurements.

B It supports international equivalence while individual results remain dispersed.

C It selects one realisation method as the permanent international standard.

D It converts each local calibration chain into a key comparison.

39. Why does paragraph F trace the chain beyond the definition and primary method?

A To show how later stages preserve a usable link to ordinary weights.

B To prove that tabletop work no longer requires electrical standards.

C To argue that customer weights should use the former prototype directly.

D To suggest that an agreed value can replace every calibration stage.

40. What practical constraint does paragraph G identify for a one-kilogram Kibble balance?

A It must use the former prototype as its reference.

B It can realise mass only at the gram level.

C It removes uncertainty when its equipment is made smaller.

D It can demand substantial space, expense and specialist operation.

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Writing

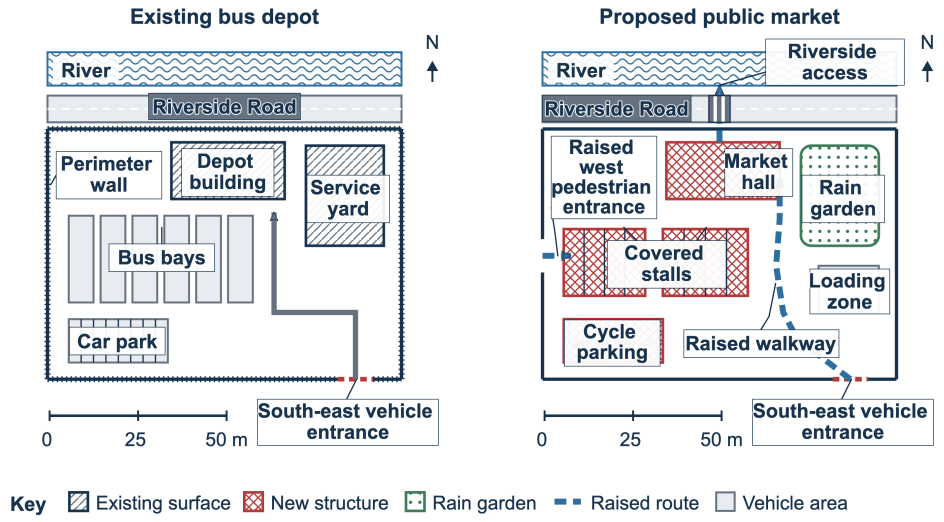
Writing Task 1

- You should spend about 20 minutes on this task.
- Write at least 150 words.

The two maps below show the same fictional riverside site in its current use as a bus depot and in a proposed layout for a flood-resilient public market.

Summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant.

Bus depot site: existing and proposed layouts



Source: WeLearn Original Practice — fictional site and proposed layout.

Writing Task 2

- You should spend about 40 minutes on this task.
- Write at least 250 words.
- Task 2 contributes twice as much as Task 1 to the Writing score.

A common wired charging connector is a physical plug that fits different portable electronic devices which accept charging through a cable. Some people think manufacturers should be required to use one such connector type for all these devices.

To what extent do you agree or disagree with this view?

Give reasons for your answer and include any relevant examples from your own knowledge or experience.

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Speaking

Part 1

Topic 1

Thank you. Now, in this first part, I'd like to ask you some questions about yourself. Let's talk about repairing things.

- Do you usually try to repair things when they break?
- Do people where you live usually repair broken things or replace them?
- Where can people learn a simple repair skill?
- Is there a repair skill you would like to learn?

Topic 2

Now let's talk about maps and finding the way.

- How often do you use a map?
- Do you prefer using a map on your phone or a paper map?
- What kinds of places do you find difficult to navigate?
- Have you ever helped someone who was lost?

Topic 3

Let's move on to public libraries.

- Are public libraries available where you live?
- What services do you think a public library can offer?
- What, if anything, do you remember about public libraries from when you were younger?
- What could make public libraries useful to more people in the future?

Part 2

- Now I'm going to give you a topic. I'd like you to talk about it for one to two minutes.
- Before you speak, you'll have one minute to prepare. You may make some notes if you wish.
- Here is your topic.

Describe an outdoor place you know about where volunteers or other local people have cared for it or tried to improve it.

You should say:

- where the place is and how you know about it
- what the people did or tried to do
- what effect their effort had, if any

and explain what you think about the way the place was looked after.

- Was this effort worthwhile? Why or why not?
- Would you like to know more about the place? Why or why not?

Thank you. We will now move on to Part 3.

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Part 3

We've been talking about people caring for an outdoor place. I'd now like to discuss the management of public outdoor spaces more generally.

- What changes, positive or negative, might people notice when community members care for a shared outdoor place?
- How should responsibility for maintaining public outdoor spaces be divided between residents and local authorities?
- What encourages people to take part in community projects, and what can prevent them from doing so?
- Why might some neighbourhoods receive more volunteer effort or public support than others, and is that fair?
- How can joint work on a public place strengthen or weaken trust between people in a community?
- In the future, what roles should governments, community groups and private companies each have in caring for public spaces?

Thank you. That is the end of the speaking test.

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Objective answer sheets

Listening

1		21	
2		22	
3		23	
4		24	
5		25	
6		26	
7		27	
8		28	
9		29	
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12		32	
13		33	
14		34	
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16		36	
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18		38	
19		39	
20		40	

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Reading

1		21	
2		22	
3		23	
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19		39	
20		40	

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Writing response paper

Task 1 - response page 1 of 2

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Task 1 - response page 2 of 2

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Task 2 - response page 1 of 3

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Task 2 - response page 2 of 3

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Speaking notes

Use notes only for the permitted preparation time.

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